the US for ‘higher studies for employment’. The letter implied that I wanted to leave ISRO after the successful flight of PSLV, but since Rao was on the verge of retirement, I did not want him the bitter feeling of a resignation. He understood it, and approved the request. The proposed US visit remained just a ruse.

As Muthunayagam was staying from work soon after Kasturirangan took over as the chairman, I made my demand to be elevated to the LPSC director post clear to Kasturirangan. When he remained non-committal, sometime in August 1994 I told Kasturirangan that I would be quitting after the next launch. He agreed.

The second launch of PSLV (D2) carrying Indian Remote Sensing Satellite (IRS-P2), on 15 October 1994 was a success, but not before some tense pre-launch moments. Towards the last leg of the countdown, a problem with a transducer, if my memory serves me right, was detected and the launch was put on hold. To set right the problem, the protocol was that the rocket had to be de-armed, meaning the fuel has to be drained, before anyone goes near the rocket.

This meant the launch could not happen within the window that day. I said I would go set right the problem, there was no need to de-arm the rocket. Engineers S Ramakrishnan (who later became VSSC director) and S Somanath (who later became LPSC director) accompanied me to the rocket. It is not exactly soothing to work on a rocket with close to 190 tonnes of solid and liquid fuels in its belly. We fixed the problem in a few minutes and the countdown resumed. It was a textbook launch.

I had kept my promise to Rao, though he had by now retired and R Kasturirangan had taken over—another reason that I found no point in continuing with ISRO without a clear career path. I could sense that G Madhavan Nair, my junior who was made PSLV project director, was waiting to be eased into the LPSC director’s chair by the new dispensation. (He followed a smooth trajectory from there to the VSSC directorship and eventually the ISRO chairmanship).

Now that the PSLV had been flown successfully, I decided to hang my ISRO boots.